

Proposal to the Ministry of Education and Sports of the Republic of Albania

From: Free Focus, a United States nonprofit organization providing technology services to nonprofits [registration number, state, year]

Contact: Dr. John Santerre — john.santerre.ai@gmail.com

Date: [date]

Subject: Request for non-financial support for Albania Now, a free education program for Albanian high-school students

What Albania Now is

Albania Now connects Albanian high-school students directly with working scientists and engineers. A student completes a four-week "sprint" of free online material on one topic — data science, planetary exploration, large language models, and others — and earns a seat in a live video lecture with the sprint's scientist, where students ask questions and hear answers in real time. Lectures are recorded and published. Completion also earns a certificate with a public verification link and a physical sticker, mailed to the student's school.

The program is optional, sits outside the normal curriculum, and is delivered in English. Seven sprints exist today, with material live at **santerre.ai/albania-now**. Confirmed speakers include Dr. Conor Nixon, Associate Laboratory Chief of the Planetary Systems Laboratory at NASA Goddard Space Flight Center; Dr. Nedelina Teneva, machine-learning research scientist, PhD University of Chicago; and Dr. John Santerre, machine-learning faculty at UC Berkeley and SMU.

Students engage through more than one door: structured sprints for students who want a path; short programming games and weekly challenges for students who start by playing; the lectures and school ceremonies as public occasions; and a moderated online community. Every door leads to the same place — a student's completed work earning a scientist's attention.

What it costs Albania

Nothing. The program is free for students and schools, permanently. Free Focus funds the platform; operating costs are modest¹ and are not part of this request. Teachers are not asked to grade, administer, or manage accounts — completion is verified by the platform itself.

What we ask — non-financial support

1. **A letter of endorsement** from the Ministry, so that school directors may share the program with students with confidence in its legitimacy.

2. **Distribution through official channels** — one circular to high-school directors describing the program, with the Ministry's knowledge attached.
3. **Computer-lab access** — the Ministry's encouragement that schools lend lab time to students whose only device is a phone, for the sprints that need a keyboard.
4. **A named liaison** in the Ministry for coordination, and guidance on parental-consent requirements for minors under Albanian data-protection law, which the platform will implement as specified.
5. **Recognition of the certificate** as a documented extracurricular achievement; a Ministry co-signature on certificates is welcome but not required.
6. **Amplification at launch** — mention through Ministry channels and public media, timed to the first cohort's closing lecture.

What the Ministry gains

- A national program of STEM and English exposure for high-school students, at zero cost to the state budget.
- Direct contact between Albanian students and scientists at institutions including NASA Goddard and UC Berkeley — contact earned by completed work, and recorded lectures that remain public afterward.
- Quarterly reporting: participation by school and region, completion counts, and lecture attendance, shared with the Ministry in full.
- Alignment with Albania's digital agenda, alongside existing initiatives such as TUMO Tirana that have shown the appetite among Albanian youth for technology education.

Safeguards

The platform collects a student's name, school, year, and email — nothing else. Stickers ship to schools, never to home addresses. Parental consent is collected for minors before any account is created. Community spaces are moderated by named adults; recordings default to chat questions read aloud by a moderator, so no student appears on camera without consent. Data is deleted on request. There are no fees, no advertisements, and no sale of data — the platform has nothing to sell.

The pilot

We propose a first cohort in *[month]*, with *[number]* schools, closing with the live lecture and a written report to the Ministry on participation and results. The Ministry's endorsement and one circular are sufficient for the pilot to begin.

Dr. John Santerre

PhD in computer science, University of Chicago; machine-learning faculty, UC Berkeley and SMU; founder, Free Focus.

[Free Focus registration details, board, address]

¹ Platform operating costs at national scale are estimated at under \$2,000 per month, funded by Free Focus; the material itself is built and maintained at no marginal cost. Detail available on request.